



SECURITY



Google says UK government has not demanded an encryption backdoor for its users' data

The U.K. government is [reportedly backing down](#) from its earlier demand that Apple build a secret backdoor allowing its authorities access to customer data worldwide, following a harsh rebuke from the U.S. government. But one U.S. senator wants to know if other tech giants, like Google, have also received secret backdoor demands from the U.K. government.

Google refused to answer the lawmaker's questions but has since told TechCrunch that the technology giant has not received a backdoor demand, marking the first time that Google has confirmed it is not subject to a similar U.K. order.

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Earlier this year, The Washington Post reported that the U.K. Home Office [sought a secret court order in the U.K.'s surveillance court](#) demanding that Apple allow U.K. authorities to access the end-to-end encrypted cloud data stored on any customer in the world, including their iPhone and iPad backups. Apple encrypts the data in such a way that only customers, and not Apple, can access their data stored on its servers.

Under U.K. law, tech companies subject to secret surveillance court orders, such as Apple, are legally barred from revealing details of an order, or the existence of the order itself, despite [details of the demand publicly leaking earlier this year](#). Critics called the secret order against Apple “draconian,” saying it would have [global ramifications for users' privacy](#). Apple has [since appealed the legality of the order](#).

In [a new letter](#) sent to top U.S. intelligence official Tulsi Gabbard on Tuesday, Sen. Ron Wyden, who serves on the Senate Intelligence Committee, said that while tech companies cannot say whether they have received a U.K. order, at least one technology giant has confirmed that it hasn't received one.

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Meta, which uses end-to-end encryption to protect user messages sent between WhatsApp and Facebook Messenger, told Wyden’s office on March 17 that the company has “not received an order to backdoor our encrypted services, like that reported about Apple.”

Google, for its part, would not tell Wyden’s office if it had received a U.K. government order for accessing encrypted data, such as Android backups, “only stating that if it had received a technical capabilities notice, it would be prohibited from disclosing that fact,” said Wyden.

Google spokesperson Karl Ryan told TechCrunch in a statement: “We have never built any mechanism or ‘backdoor’ to circumvent end-to-end encryption in our products. If we say a product is end-to-end encrypted, it is.”

When explicitly asked by TechCrunch, Ryan said: “We haven’t received a technical capabilities notice,” referring to any U.K. surveillance order.

Wyden’s letter, first reported by [The Washington Post](#) and [shared with TechCrunch](#), called on Gabbard to make public its “assessment of the national security risks posed by the U.K.’s surveillance laws and its reported secret demands of U.S. companies.”

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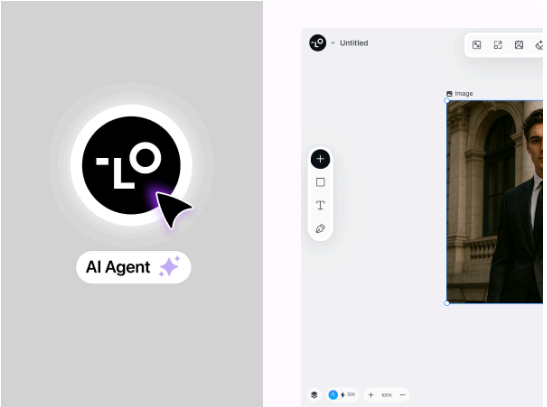
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This story was updated with additional comment from Google, shared in response to a TechCrunch inquiry.

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AI



OpenAI is practically giving ChatGPT to the government for free

Rebecca Bellan — 10:09 AM PDT · August 6, 2025

OpenAI is poised to undercut rivals like Anthropic and Google in the race to see its AI tools integrated into federal agency workflows.

The AI giant has [reached an agreement](#) with the U.S. General Services Administration (GSA), the government's central purchasing arm, to offer ChatGPT Enterprise to participating federal agencies for just \$1 per agency for the next year.

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The partnership comes a day after the [GSA added OpenAI, Google, and Anthropic](#) to a list of approved AI vendors that can offer their services to civilian federal agencies. The companies will see their tools offered via the Multiple Award Schedule (MAS), a federal contracting platform that lets government agencies access AI tools via pre-negotiated contracts so they don't have to negotiate with vendors individually.

It's not clear whether other AI firms are going to offer their services at such a discounted rate, though GSA Federal Acquisition Service commissioner Josh Gruenbaum in a [statement](#) encouraged "other American AI technology companies to follow OpenAI's lead and work with us."

TechCrunch has reached out to Anthropic and Google for more information.

In addition to access to ChatGPT Enterprise, OpenAI is offering unlimited use of advanced models for an additional 60 days. Federal employees will also have access to a new government user community and tailored introductory training resources to get familiar with OpenAI's tools.

Data security is a top priority for government agencies that are concerned about sensitive information being leaked into model training sets. TechCrunch has asked the GSA for details on how government data is being safeguarded, including whether measures like on-premises or private cloud deployments are being used to enhance security.

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“The government is taking a cautious, security-first approach to AI,” a GSA spokesperson told TechCrunch. “This ensures sensitive information remains protected while enabling agencies to benefit from AI-driven efficiencies.”

OpenAI's discount comes a couple of weeks after the Trump administration published its AI Action Plan that seeks to boost data center buildouts and integrate more AI tools into government, among other things. It also follows a Trump executive order that [bans “woke AI”](#) and AI models that aren't “ideologically neutral” from government contracts.

TechCrunch has reached out to OpenAI to learn more about its GSA partnership and how it will approach Trump's executive order.

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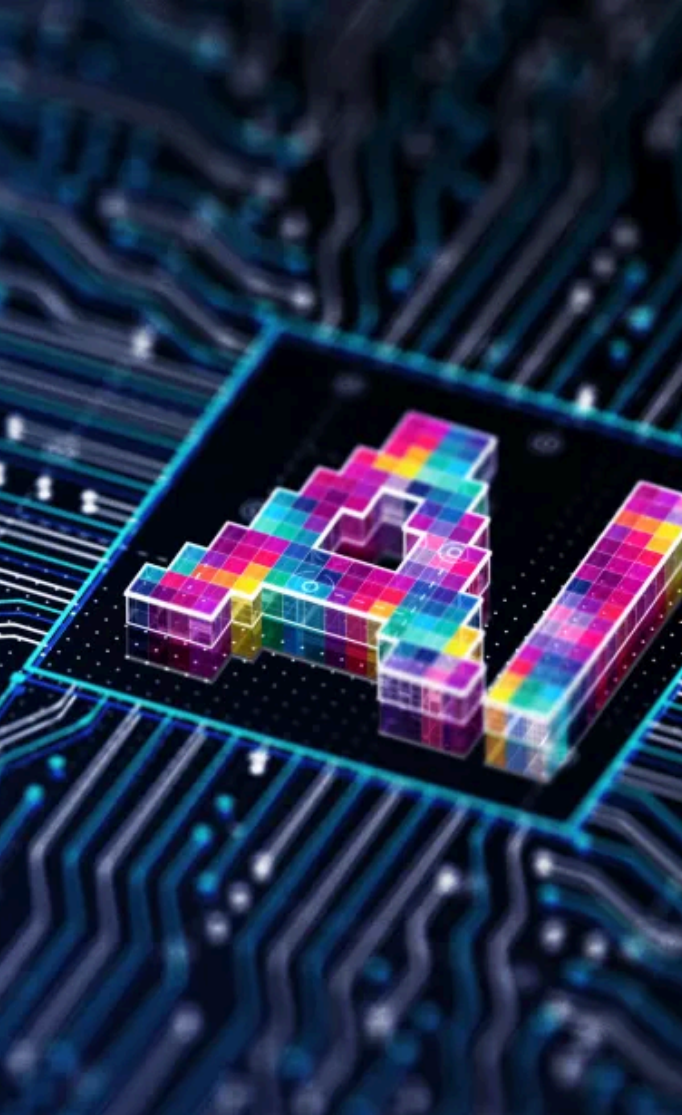


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AI



Two arrested for smuggling AI chips to China — Nvidia says no to kill switches

Rebecca Szkutak — 6:02 AM PDT · August 6, 2025

The U.S. Department of Justice (DOJ) [said](#) on Tuesday that two Chinese nationals have been arrested for their alleged involvement in illegally shipping tens of millions of dollars' worth of high-performance AI chips to China.

The DOJ said Chuan Geng and Shiwei Yang were arrested in California on August 2 and charged with violating the Export Control Reform Act, a felony that carries a statutory penalty of a maximum of 20 years in prison.

Geng and Yang are accused of knowing and willfully shipping “sensitive technologies,” including GPUs, to China from the U.S. through their California-based company, ALX Solutions.

The DOJ did not name the company whose chips ALX Solutions was allegedly smuggling, but quoting a complaint, it said the chip is “the most powerful chip in the market” and is “designed specifically for AI applications.” That description

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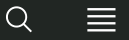


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Marina Temkin - 7 hours ago

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our products to well-known partners, including OEMs, who help us ensure that all sales comply with U.S. export control rules. Even relatively small exporters and shipments are subject to thorough review and scrutiny, and any diverted products would have no service, support, or updates.”

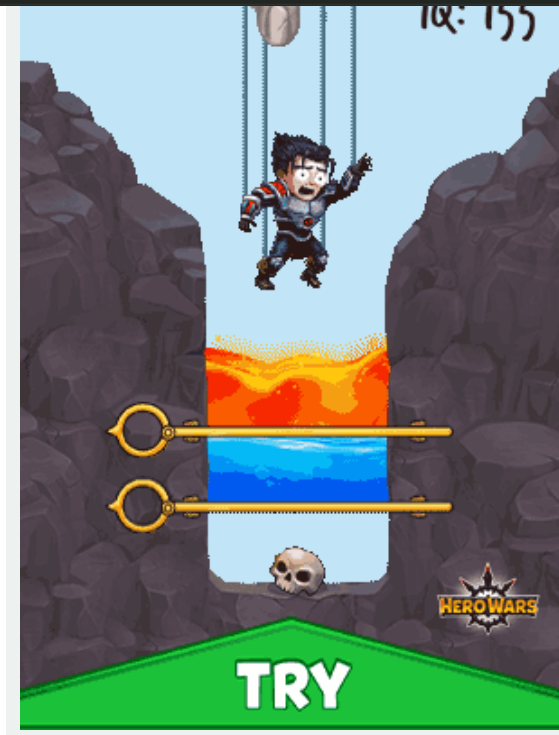
The news comes as the U.S. tries to figure out how to strike a balance between fostering global AI innovation and imposing export restrictions to China, which many in the West perceive to be a major threat in the AI race. The Trump administration’s recently announced [AI Action Plan](#) belabored the importance of having strong export restrictions but was light on details.

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One potential solution to curb chip smuggling that has been suggested by the U.S. government in recent days is to [implement tracking technology into chips](#) to help catch smuggling, but chipmakers are quite opposed to such a move.

In a [blog post on Tuesday](#), Nvidia said its GPUs do not include kill switches or backdoors, and argued that building in such tools would only result in compromising security.

“Nvidia has been designing processors for over 30 years. Embedding backdoors and kill switches into chips would be a gift to hackers and hostile actors,” the company wrote. “It would undermine global digital infrastructure and fracture trust in U.S. technology. Established law wisely requires companies to fix vulnerabilities — not create them.”

“That’s not sound policy. It’s an overreaction that would irreparably harm America’s economic and national security interests,” Nvidia wrote.

Nvidia did not immediately return requests for additional comment.

For more on the semiconductor industry’s tumultuous year so far, here’s a [regularly updated timeline](#) of market news since the beginning of 2025.

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SECURITY



Citizen Lab director warns cyber industry about US authoritarian descent

Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai

— 8:01 AM PDT · August 6, 2025

Ron Deibert, the director of Citizen Lab, one of the most prominent organizations investigating government spyware abuses, is sounding the alarm to the cybersecurity community and asking them to step up and join the fight against authoritarianism.

On Wednesday, Deibert [will deliver a keynote](#) at the Black Hat cybersecurity conference in Las Vegas, one of the largest gatherings of information security professionals of the year.

Ahead of his talk, Deibert told TechCrunch that he plans to speak about what he describes as a “descent into a kind of fusion of tech and fascism,” and the role that the Big Tech platforms are playing, and “propelling forward a really

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frightening type of collective insecurity that isn't typically addressed by this crowd, this community, as a cybersecurity problem."

Deibert described the recent political events in the United States as a "dramatic descent into authoritarianism," but one that the cybersecurity community can help defend against.

"I think alarm bells need to be rung for this community that, at the very least, they should be aware of what's going on and hopefully they can not contribute to it, if not help reverse it," Deibert told TechCrunch.

Historically, at least in the United States, the cybersecurity industry has put politics — to a certain extent — to the side. More recently, however, politics has fully entered the world of cybersecurity.

Earlier this year, President Donald Trump [ordered an investigation into former CISA director Chris Krebs](#), who had publicly rebuffed Trump's false claims about election fraud by declaring the 2020 election secure. Trump later [fired Krebs by tweet](#). The investigation ordered by Trump months after his 2024 reelection forced Krebs to [step down from SentinelOne and vow to fight back](#).

In response, Jen Easterly, another former CISA director and Krebs' successor, [called on the cybersecurity community to get involved](#) and speak out.

"If we stay silent when experienced, mission-driven leaders are sidelined or sanctioned, we risk something greater than discomfort; we risk diminishing the very institutions we are here to protect," Easterly wrote in a post on LinkedIn.

Easterly was herself [a victim of political pressure](#) from the Trump administration when her offer to join West Point was rescinded in late July.

Deibert, who this year [published his new book](#), "Chasing Shadows: Cyber Espionage, Subversion, and the Global Fight for Democracy," is echoing the same message as Easterly.

"I think that there comes a point at which you have to recognize that the landscape is changing around you, and the security problems you set out for yourselves are maybe trivial in light of the broader context and the insecurities that are

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being propelled forward in the absence of proper checks and balances and oversight, which are deteriorating,” said Deibert.

Deibert is also concerned that big companies like Meta, Google, and Apple could take a step back in their efforts to fight against government spyware — [sometimes referred](#) to as “commercial” or “mercenary” spyware — by gutting their threat intelligence teams.

These threat intelligence teams are dedicated groups of security researchers that track government hackers, both those working inside government agencies, such as China’s Ministry of State Security or Russia’s intelligence agencies FSB and GRU, and companies such as NSO Group or Paragon.

These are the same teams that are responsible for detecting hacks against their own users, such as when [WhatsApp caught NSO Group](#) hacking more than 1,400 of its users in 2019, or when Apple caught hackers using government spyware to target its customers and [notified the victims](#) of the [attacks](#).

Deibert believes there is a “huge market failure when it comes to cybersecurity for global civil society,” a part of the population that generally cannot afford to get help from big security companies that typically serve governments and corporate clients. “This market failure is going to get more acute as supporting institutions evaporate and attacks on civil society amplify,” he said.

“Whatever they can do to contribute to offset this market failure (e.g., pro bono work) will be essential to the future of liberal democracy worldwide,” he said.

Deibert is concerned that these threat intelligence teams could be cut or at least reduced, given that the same companies have cut their moderation and safety teams.

He told TechCrunch that threat intelligence teams, like the ones at Meta, are doing “amazing work,” in part by staying siloed and separate from the commercial arms of their wider organizations.

“But the question is how long will that last?” said Deibert.

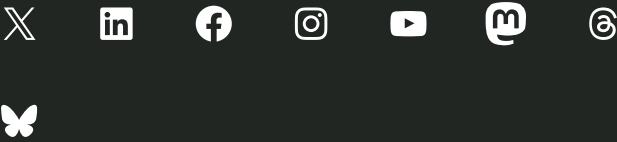


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